

In this paper, I demonstrated a strong understanding of career counseling theory, particularly Social Cognitive Career Theory (SCCT), and how it could be applied to support individuals with disabilities. At the time, my focus was largely on understanding concepts, research, and treatment planning from an academic perspective. Looking back, I can see that I was developing the foundation of my counseling identity, but I had not yet experienced the complexity of working directly with clients.

Since writing this paper, my growth has come through hands-on clinical experience. Working with children, adolescents, and families has taught me that counseling is far more nuanced than applying a theory to a case. While I still value evidence-based approaches such as CBT, person-centered therapy, and strengths-based interventions, I have learned that the therapeutic relationship is often the most important factor in helping clients create change. I have become more comfortable sitting with difficult emotions, adapting interventions to individual needs, and recognizing that progress rarely follows a straight line.

I also notice growth in my understanding of barriers and systems. In this paper, I discussed environmental barriers affecting employment for individuals with disabilities. Through clinical work, I have developed a deeper appreciation for how family dynamics, trauma, socioeconomic factors, culture, and access to resources influence a person's ability to thrive. Rather than focusing solely on problems, I now actively look for strengths, resilience, and opportunities for empowerment.

Most importantly, I have grown in confidence. While I still have much to learn, I no longer view counseling only through a theoretical lens. I have developed practical skills, clinical judgment, and a greater understanding of how to connect with clients in meaningful ways. This

growth has transformed me from a student learning about counseling into a counselor actively practicing it.